sometimes brazenly walking past our check-post after showing the jawan on duty a fictitious identity card, or wearing a burkha. In one particularly ruthless attack, he had remotely blown up an ice-cream trolley packed with explosives, killing seven security forces personnel on the spot. That the ice-cream vendor was also blown up was of no concern to him. Such acts had made him notorious and high on the police wanted list. I asked Razzaq about these traits.

'Sahib, he had no choice,' he said. 'Once he took up the gun, he had to spread terror. That was the only way he could remain safe; only if the people feared him more than the police or the Army. He made a reputation for himself and then he had to live up to that reputation.'

'Yes, but why did he pick up the gun in the first place?'

'Sahib, you only tell me. I am a poor man. About seven or eight years ago, there was this police informer called Mir. He had spread a reign of terror in our area. Under the pretext of working for the police, he used to extort money from all of us. If we did not oblige, he would give the police some fictitious information and that person would be picked up by them, sometimes never to be seen again. I too was picked up but released. After my release from custody, Mir came to my house again late one night and demanded one lakh rupees. Where was I to get so much money from? When I told him I could not pay up,' sobbed Razzaq, his frail body convulsing, 'he demanded my wife.'

Putting an arm around his shoulders, I listened as he continued his tale.

'Mustafa was but a boy of fourteen when this happened. And when that monster came back again a few days later and tried to molest my elder daughter, it was too much for Mustafa. He joined the militants and was sent to Pakistan.'

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